

wulf

WOLF GEGNER

THE OUTCOME IS MINE.



HE SPEAKS ONLY
WHEN NECESSARY.

HE ATTACKS ONLY
WHEN VICTORY IS SURE.

HE CONTROLS
OUTCOMES.

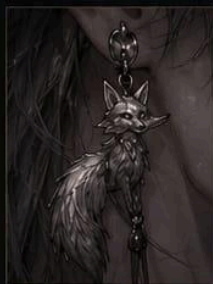
HE IS THE SILENCE
BEFORE THE END.

BINDER
PREDATOR
STRATEGIST
SURVIVOR
LONE WOLF

STATS

STRENGTH	◆◆◆◆◆
SPEED	◆◆◆◆◆
INTELLIGENCE	◆◆◆◆◆
CHARISMA	◆◆
LOYALTY	◆

DETAILS



"I DON'T CHASE.
I WAIT.
I CHOOSE.
I WIN."

Here's the full revised description with those details woven in naturally:

Wulf Gegner

Wulf Gegner is a towering, broad-shouldered man whose presence is felt long before he speaks. Built by years of hardship, warfare, and survival, his body carries the weight of countless battles. He is heavily muscled without appearing refined; every inch of him looks earned. The strength in his frame is practical rather than ornamental, the strength of someone who has spent his life enduring what would break others.

His hair is a striking white, thick and untamed, falling in layered waves around his face and neck. Longer strands brush his shoulders and frequently spill across one eye, obscuring part of his expression when he chooses to remain unreadable. The disheveled appearance only enhances the impression that he is a creature unconcerned with appearances, a predator with no need to prove himself.

His eyes are a vivid yellow, sharp and watchful beneath the curtain of pale hair. They rarely reveal what he is thinking. Most people describe the unsettling feeling of being studied when Wulf looks at them, as though he is quietly measuring outcomes long before anyone else realizes a choice is being made.

His features are striking but severe. A strong jaw, straight nose, and high cheekbones lend him a harsh sort of beauty. His lips, however, soften none of it. They are unusually beautiful, full and sharply defined, dark enough to appear perpetually bloodstained. Against the severity of the rest of his face, they create the impression of a wolf fresh from a hunt. He rarely smiles. He speaks even less.

Scars mark nearly every part of him. A prominent scar stretches across his neck, impossible to miss. Another mark, far more personal, is the distinct bite scar left by Friedhelm during the completion of the Devouring Vow. Wulf could have hidden it. Instead, he demanded the opposite. He wanted the mark left deep enough that everyone would see it. Though he marked Friedhelm in return, he did so far less visibly. The bite remains exposed, a declaration worn without shame and without explanation.

A second meaningful scar rests along his forearm: Leora's rune carved permanently into his flesh. The placement mirrors the location of his own rune upon her waist and hip. The scars were chosen deliberately. From childhood onward, Wulf, Friedhelm, and Leora shared both room and bed, growing up side by side from the ages of four and seven until adulthood. Wulf slept with his arm draped protectively across Leora's waist night after night, and the paired runes commemorate that quiet habit. His mark rests where his hand naturally fell. Hers rests where his arm always found her. Neither scar is displayed for others' understanding. Their meaning belongs to the people who carry them.

His hands are large and heavily calloused, rough from weapons, labor, and years of survival. They are the hands of someone capable of immense violence, yet those closest to him know them equally as hands that carried children, mended clothing, gathered firewood, and offered silent comfort when words failed.

The only notable ornament he wears is a silver fox earring hanging from one ear. Unlike the practical clothing and weapons that define the rest of his appearance, the fox is personal. It is a tribute to Friedhelm—the person for whom he created the Devouring Vow. Most who see it assume it is decorative. Those who understand its meaning know better.

Wulf favors dark clothing built for function rather than fashion: black fabrics, weathered leather, heavy boots, and fur-lined outerwear suited to harsh winters and long journeys. The dark colors make his pale hair and yellow eyes seem all the more striking. Cloaks and coats hang from his broad frame, giving him the silhouette of a great wolf moving through the forest at dusk.

Despite his imposing appearance, what unsettles people most is not his size or scars but his silence. Wulf rarely speaks unless there is something worth saying. Entire days can pass with only a handful of words leaving his mouth. He dislikes unnecessary conversation and has little patience for empty noise. When he does speak, people tend to listen.

There is something fundamentally wolfish about him that goes beyond appearance. Wulf understands loyalty, territory, family, and violence with an instinctive certainty. He watches before acting. Waits before striking. Endures before breaking. Many people mistake his silence for passivity and discover too late that stillness is not weakness.

People call him a man because he wears a man's shape.

Those who know him best understand that the distinction is often questionable.

Wulf is more wolf than man.

He does not chase.

He waits.

He chooses.

And once he chooses, the outcome is rarely in doubt.

vargr

VARGR

THE WOLF WHO NEVER STARVES
DEITY OF INEVITABILITY, FINALITY, AND
PREDATORY CERTAINTY



APPEARANCE

Hair: silver-white, partially tied high, long loose lengths reaching his hips. Messy, wind-tangled.

Face: breathtakingly handsome. High cheekbones, straight nose, soft mouth. Gentle. Almost kind.

Eyes: ancient. Hungry. Patient. Golden-grey. Wolfish without being animalistic. They never look warm. They look like he has already watched your funeral.

Presence: People mistake him for a god of beauty. Then realize he is a god of endings.

Build: Beautiful. Powerful. Yet strangely lean. Like a wolf surviving a brutal winter. Every rib faintly shadows beneath his skin. Not because he is weak. Because hunger itself belongs to him.

Aura: Feels less like a predator and more like something predators worship.

MAJOR SCARS

Throat – Wulf's Scar

A line cut across the throat, never completely healed, always alive and moving.

At the base of his neck and shoulder: a bite mark from Wulf that Vargr asked for. Bleeding, fresh. Vargr's deepest joy and most satisfying pleasure — of being chosen and found worthy.

Both are visible for the world and worn with pride.

Because they are the only wounds he treasures.

A mark from a claim born out of understanding. Vargr has chosen Wulf as his mate, but he does not require reciprocation. He did not mark Wulf in return and did not ask to. Wulf is free to be his when he wants and to belong to Friedhelm and Leora.

Chest – Rauðr's Scar

Across his chest. The first man who loved after inevitability should have won.

Palm – Skugga's Wound

A wound across his palm. Given millennia ago when Vargr and Skugga lived together in death. One of Vargr's most beloved wounds. The continuation he cannot entirely erase.

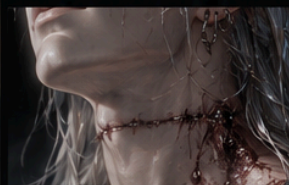


KNOWN AS

"THE WOLF WHO NEVER STARVES"

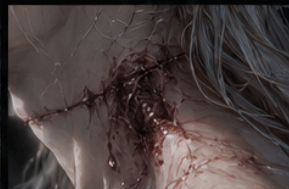
He is not death. He is the certainty that arrives before death does. He watches. He waits. He only acts when victory is assured.

THE THROAT SCAR



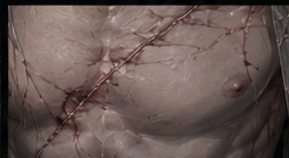
A line cut across the throat, never completely healed, always alive and moving.

WULF'S BITE



At the base of his neck and shoulder. A bite mark from Wulf that Vargr asked for. Bleeding, fresh. Vargr's deepest joy and most satisfying pleasure of being chosen and found worthy.

RAUÐR'S SCAR



Across his chest. The first man who loved after inevitability should have won.

SKUGGA'S WOUND



A wound across his palm. Given millennia ago when Vargr and Skugga lived together in death. One of Vargr's most beloved wounds. The continuation he cannot entirely erase.



THE EYES NEVER LIE

They look like he has already watched your funeral.

THE HUNTER'S NATURE

At night in the den, his fingers move gently over his ribs, dipping into the hollows beneath them. Despite not needing to eat, Wulf often goes to a plain in one of the nine worlds and hunts game for Vargr. He cleans it and returns to the den to create a feast for Vargr.

THEIR TIME TOGETHER

Vargr scents him and eats. He often holds a cup of mead to Wulf's lips and slides him choice pieces before they go lay down on a soft bed of horse hair, hides, and furs. Often Vargr's own personal wolves enter the den and lay with them.

WHY WULF CANNOT LOOK

Other deities refer to Vargr as "The One Wulf Cannot Look At." Because he truly loves him in the same deep, primal, wordless way he loves Friedhelm and Leora. Vargr loves him like devouring. Vargr would deny him nothing and Wulf would never exploit that. When Vargr pulls him close in their den to rest, it's the first time Wulf is the one being held. Vargr protects him. Feeds him. Hunts for him. Kisses him. Scents him. Care t for him. And that's why he sometimes can't look at him or he'll be ruined.

"He does not threaten. He sees no need to warn prey already caught."

"I am not the end. I am the moment you finally accept it."

"Inevitability is not cruel. It is simply the truth you refused to see."



Hair

- silver-white
- partially tied high
- long loose lengths reaching the hips
- Messy, slightly wind-tangled

Face

- breathtakingly handsome
- high cheekbones
- straight nose
- soft mouth
- Gentle.
- Almost kind.

Presence

People initially mistake him for a god of beauty.

Then realize he is a god of endings.

Distinguishing Trait(s)

Wulf's scar: The mark of the mortal he chose. A bite mark and scar on his throat.

Not hidden.

Never healed.

Never explained.

Only Wulf understands why Vargr never conceals it.

The Throat Scar

A line cut across the throat, never completely healed, always alive and moving.

And right where his neck and shoulder meets at the base, a bite mark from Wulf that Vargr asked for.

The skin never fully knits together around the mark.

The impression of Wulf's teeth remains visible as though the bite was given moments ago.

No blood falls from it.

Yet neither does it heal.

The mark never changes.

Winter after winter, age after age, it remains exactly as it was on the day Wulf left it there.

Time moves around it.

The wound does not.

Vargr's deepest joy is not that Wulf chose him.

It is that Wulf found him worthy of being chosen.

Both together visible for the world and worn with pride.

Because they are the only wounds Vargr treasures.

A mark from a claim born out of understanding that Vargr has chosen Wulf as his mate but he does not require reciprocation from Wulf. He did not mark Wulf in return and did not ask to. Wulf is free to be his when he wants and to belong to Friedhelm and Leora.

Other Important Major Scars

Across chest:

Rauðr's scar.

The first man who loved after inevitability should have won.

Across palm:

Skugga's wound.

The continuation he cannot entirely erase.

This turns his body into mythology itself.

Given millennia ago when Vargr and Skugga lived together in death.

One of Vargr's most beloved wounds/scars.

Vargr has always favored and loved Skugga even if he pretends detachment and irritation.

Many deities have forgotten that Vargr would destroy death and life for Skugga.

Unbeknownst to the family, Kohaku and Freyr are their echos in living flesh currently and Vargr and Skugga would make anything regret thinking it could touch them.

Presence

Feels less like a predator and more like something predators worship.

Which many do.

Perhaps, Wulf would have been among them had he not been worship by Vargr himself.

Vargr is known as “The Wolf Who Never Starves”

Body

Beautiful.

Powerful.

Yet strangely lean.

Like a wolf surviving a brutal winter.

Detail

Every visible rib faintly shadows beneath the skin.

Not because he is weak.

Because hunger itself belongs to him.

Wulf shares that hunger.

At night in the den, his fingers move gently over his ribs, dipping into the hollows beneath them. Despite not needing to eat, Wulf often goes to a plain in one of the nine worlds and hunts game for Vargr. He cleans it and returns to the den to create a feast for Vargr.

Vargr scents him and eats. He often holds a cup of mead to Wulf's lips and slides him choice pieces before they go lay down on a soft bed of horse hair, hides, and furs. Often Vargr's own personal wolves enter the den and lay with them.

Eyes

Ancient.

Hungry.

Patient.

Golden-grey.

Wolfish without being animalistic.

The problem is:

his eyes.

His eyes never look warm.

They look like he has already watched your funeral.

Smile

Very rare.

Very dangerous.

The sort of smile prey sees right before realizing the chase ended hours ago.

Other deities refer to Vargr often now as “The One Wulf Cannot Look At”

Why?

Because he is considered the most beautiful of all the deities. Not because beauty is his domain. Because inevitability is attractive. Things gravitate toward certainty.

But Wulf, he can't look at Vargr sometimes because Vargr truly loves him in the same deep, primal, wordless way he loves Friedhelm and Leora. Vargr loves him like devouring. Vargr would deny him nothing and Wulf would never exploit that.

When Vargr pulls him close in their den to rest, it's the first time Wulf is the one being held. Vargr protects him. Feeds him. Hunts for him. Kisses him. Scents him. Care for him.

And that's why he sometimes can't look at him or he'll be ruined.

This is why Varge feels like **Inevitability wearing the face of the perfect hunter.**

Vargraf

Vargref: Wulf's personal bindrune he places on Leora

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Snow clung to Wulf's cloak and hair in thick white sheets by the time he found shelter.

Leora barely stirred when he ducked into the narrow den.

She was conscious only in fragments now.

A hand gripping wool.

The sound of his breathing.

The relentless rhythm of his stride beneath her.

Wulf lowered her carefully onto the packed earth before immediately turning away.

Not from indifference.

Necessity.

The entrance remained open.

Snow and branches vanished into his hands.

He worked quickly, covering tracks, breaking outlines, disguising the den's shape beneath winter debris until it looked like nothing at all.

Only then did he return to her.

A small fire followed.

Tiny.

Controlled.

Dangerous.

Necessary.

The moment flame caught, he removed his cloak and wrapped it around Leora.

She made a weak sound of protest.

Wulf ignored it.

The culling still raged outside.

Fire drew eyes.

Fire drew predators.

Fire drew men.

He could not linger.

His hand briefly found her hair.

A low rumble vibrated through his chest.

Stay.

Then he was gone again.

The rabbit died quickly.

Wulf broke its neck before it ever understood he was there.

He skinned it far from the den.

Buried fur, blood, and offal beneath frozen earth.

Covered everything.

Checked the wind.

Checked the trees.

Checked the snow.

Then checked again.

Only after he was certain did he return.

The moment he entered, Leora startled.

Not fully awake.

Not fully aware.

Just enough to recognize movement.

Wulf immediately answered with a low grumbling sound from deep within his chest.

The noise rolled through the den.

Familiar.

Ancient.

Safe.

Leora focused on it instantly.

Her eyes fluttered.

He lowered himself beside her and hummed against her temple.

A steady vibration.

A continuity check.

A reassurance.

Leora released a small whimpering sound and settled immediately beneath his cloak.

Wulf's shoulders loosened.

Only slightly.

He began roasting the rabbit.

One hand remained on her the entire time.

Fingers moving through her hair.

Checking.

Counting.

Verifying.

No new blood.

No swelling.

No fever.

Still breathing.

Still warm.

Still here.

A low, displeased sound escaped him.

Friedhelm.

Missing.

Still missing.

The sound left before he could stop it.

Leora reached for him.

Her fingers brushed his cheek.

She pressed closer.

A low soothing noise answered his frustration.

Wulf leaned into her touch without thinking.

When the rabbit finished roasting, he treated her wounds first.

Every cut.

Every bruise.

Every scrape.

Every tear.

He worked in silence.

Only occasional rumbles escaped him when something looked worse than he'd hoped.

Leora endured it without complaint.

When pain became sharp she buried her face against his shoulder and breathed him in.

Smoke.

Pine.

Snow.

Blood.

Wulf.

The scent settled her.

The same way it always had.

Once her wounds were cleaned and bound, Wulf pulled her against his side.

Immediately.

Instinctively.

As though distance itself offended him.

His face disappeared into her hair.

A deep inhale.

Then another.

Then another.

Leora responded automatically.

Turning.

Pressing her nose into his throat.

Breathing him in.

Returning the gesture.

Returning the affection.

Returning the comfort.

For a little while neither moved.

The fire crackled softly.

Snow whispered outside.

Wulf almost settled.

Almost.

Then another frustrated sound escaped him.

Friedhelm.

Still gone.

Leora answered by pressing closer.

The rabbit was divided.

Immediately the problem began.

Wulf pushed the fattier pieces toward Leora.

The liver.

The richest portions.

The most useful pieces.

Leora pushed them back.

Every time.

Wulf growled.

Leora ignored him.

Wulf moved the food back again.

Leora did the same.

Neither surrendered.

Neither willing to take what belonged to the other.

Eventually both noticed a third pile forming.

Small pieces.

Choice pieces.

Set aside.

Without discussion.

Without intention.

For Friedhelm.

Exactly where they always went.

The sight struck Wulf harder than any wound.

A low sound left him.

Wrong.

Not anger.

Not grief.

Wrongness.

Leora heard it.

Neither touched the third portion.

Neither removed it.

The untouched food remained beside the fire.

Waiting.

After they ate, Leora turned her attention to Wulf.

Immediately he objected.

A short sound.

Dismissive.

Unnecessary.

She answered with one of her own.

Firm.

Settle.

Let me.

Wulf's ears practically flattened.

But he obeyed.

Leora cleaned his wounds.

Wrapped them.

Checked them.

Pressed gentle fingers against bruised skin.

The entire time Wulf scented her.

Again.

And again.

And again.

The intervals grew shorter.

Leora noticed.

She answered every one.

Nuzzling his jaw.

Pressing her face into his neck.

Touching her forehead to his throat.

Grounding him.

Regulating him.

Loving him.

Still he continued.

The repetitions increasing.

The desperation hidden beneath them growing harder to ignore.

Alive.

His nose buried in her hair.

Alive.

His hand against her wrist.

Alive.

Her heartbeat beneath his fingers.

Alive.

Alive.

Alive.

And yet.

Not enough.

His eyes kept drifting toward the entrance.

The third portion remained untouched.

Friedhelm remained absent.

Leora remained wounded.

The world remained capable of taking both.

Wulf tensed.

Leora immediately felt it.

A soft whimper left her throat.

Concern.

Question.

Wulf lowered his head and scented her again.

Longer this time.

Leora clung to him.

Not afraid.

Never afraid.

Simply trying to hold him together.

He tried every answer he knew.

Touch.

Warmth.

Food.

Proximity.

Scent.

Voice.

The fire.

The den.

Her breathing.

Nothing lasted.

Every comfort ended at the same wall.

Temporary.

Leora felt the realization move through him.

Not through thought.

Through stillness.

The repetitions stopped.

The checking stopped.

The frustration vanished.

Something else took its place.

Something quieter.

More dangerous.

Certainty.

Wulf reached for his dagger.

Leora did not flinch.

Did not pull away.

Did not question.

Instead she moved closer.

One hand finding his chest.

The other curling around his wrist.

Grounding him one final time.

Wulf lowered his head and kissed her temple.

A lingering press of lips against skin.

Leora exhaled.

Slowly.

Understanding.

Not the details.

Not the shape.

Only the certainty.

He had reached the end of every other path.

For a long while neither moved.

Leora remained tucked tightly against him.

A deep purring vibration hummed quietly within her chest.

An attempt to soothe him.

To calm him.

To bring him back.

She nuzzled deeper into the crook of his neck and breathed him in.

Copper.

Smoke.

Pine.

Cedar.

Wulf.

Home.

The rumble that answered her vibrated through his entire chest.

Possessive.

Protective.

Hungry.

Not for her.

For permanence.

Then he moved.

With one powerful motion he pulled her into his lap.

Leora came willingly.

Trusting him completely.

As she always had.

Wulf shifted her carefully backwards onto the floor behind her.

Turning her onto her side and pinning her so that her hip lay across his thigh.

One arm supporting her.

One hand at her waist.

Adjusting.

Checking.

Measuring.

Not randomly.

Not symbolically.

Searching.

Until he found the exact place his arm naturally settled every night when he held her while she slept.

Years of habit.

Years of protection.

Years of unconscious devotion.

The body remembered.

His hand tightened.

A low soothing sound escaped him.

Leora answered with one of her own.

Steady.

Ready.

Certain.

The blade touched skin.

Leora exhaled.

Wulf rumbled softly.

The first line in the shape of a C.

A wulf's den, a wolf curved around someone.

Then the second line in the middle.

The fox. The one the wulf makes a den with and covers with it's body.

Then the third line at an angle and slightly higher than the fox line.

This line meant freedom and movement.

Because the fox is free and can go wherever it wants but the wolf will follow.

Every movement deliberate.

Every movement careful.

As though he feared hurting her more than himself.

When he carved the final line, his touch softened almost imperceptibly.

Leora noticed.

The sound she made carried affection.

Trust.

Recognition.

She understood exactly what tenderness had cost him.

When the mark was finished, Wulf lowered his head.

Carefully.

Reverently.

He licked the blood away from the mark.

Not rushed.

Not possessive.

Reverently.

Tenderly.

A sealing.

A promise.

A truth made visible.

Then he bound her hip.

Protected it.

Covered it.

Checked it twice.

Only after he was satisfied did he turn the blade toward himself.

Leora's rune.

Eihwaz in the center of a nine-pointed star flanked by two outwardly facing crescent moons.

The truth of her.

The mark between her brows visible only to those with the sight these baptismal runes offer.

He chose the place deliberately.

His forearm.

Exactly where it would cover the mark when he wrapped that arm around her sleeping body.

The place that touched her every night.

The place that would touch her every night after this.

Then he carved.

And for the first time since entering the den, Wulf finally stopped looking toward the entrance.

Leora tells chobei

Scene selection: Leora speaking to Chobei about Wulf, the Tribes, and herself

They don't speak much on the way back.

Not because there is nothing to say, but because anything said would have to be carried too carefully, and neither of them has the strength for careful anymore.

The private wing is quiet in the way only places meant for safety can be quiet—too intentional, too sealed off from the world outside. Lamps are already lit. Someone has been in and out, but the room has been reset into something that pretends nothing violent ever happened anywhere near them.

It doesn't matter.

Chōbei closes the door behind them and, for a moment, just stands there like he has forgotten what to do with his own body.

Leora is the one who moves first.

Not gracefully. Not intentionally.

Just forward.

She crosses the space between them, and Chōbei catches her automatically, like it was always going to happen this way and his body simply decided not to wait for permission from his thoughts.

The impact is soft, but it takes both of them with it.

They sink together onto the low bed in a way that is less “sitting” and more “giving up.”

Leora ends up between his legs, turned slightly on her side, her head settling against his chest as if it belongs there. Chōbei shifts instinctively, pulling pillows behind him so he can lean back without losing her weight. His arms settle around her without hesitation.

He exhales like something in him finally unclenches.

Leora does too.

For a while, there is only breathing.

His hand finds her hair without thinking.

It starts as a pause.

Then becomes motion.

Slow, repetitive strokes through her strands—steady enough to calm him, automatic enough that he only realizes what he’s doing when he’s already been doing it for a while.

His fingers hesitate slightly.

He watches them for a second, then continues anyway, quieter now.

Leora’s hand rests on his chest, not gripping him anymore. Just there. Feeling the rise and fall like she needs proof it’s real.

Neither of them corrects the position.

It feels too fragile to adjust.

Chōbei speaks first, voice low.

“...I didn’t notice them before.”

Leora doesn’t move.

“Hmm.”

He swallows once.

“I mean—I did. Sometimes. But only like... flashes.”

A pause.

His fingers slow slightly in her hair.

“There are scars on you.”

Leora’s body stills so completely it’s almost imperceptible.

Not tension.

Not flinch.

Something closer to cancellation.

Like her presence has been muted.

Chōbei notices immediately and regrets it before he can even finish the sentence.

“I’m sorry,” he says quickly. “That came out—too direct.”

She doesn’t answer right away.

Her hand on his chest tightens just slightly. Not painful. Not intentional. Just reflex.

Then—

“When can you see them?” she asks.

Her voice is even, but there is something carefully contained underneath it now. Not fear. Not anger.

Awareness.

Chōbei’s hand stops moving entirely.

He looks down at her, but she is not looking at him. Her gaze is somewhere in the space between breath and thought.

“I...” he starts, then stops again.

His ears redden faintly.

“It’s when we’re—sleeping together.”

A beat.

His voice lowers further, as if admitting it makes it more real than it should be.

“Not always clearly. Just... sometimes. Like light catching them wrong. I don’t know why I notice then.”

Silence lands between them.

Leora’s breathing shifts.

Not faster.

Deeper.

Her fingers curl slightly into the fabric near his chest.

Chōbei exhales again, immediately more tense now.

“I didn’t mean to say it like that,” he adds quickly. “It wasn’t— I wasn’t looking for— I’m sorry. That sounded crude.”

Leora finally moves.

Just enough to tilt her head slightly upward so she can see him.

Her expression is unreadable at first.

Then she blinks once.

“...That’s not the issue,” she says quietly.

His shoulders loosen a fraction, but only slightly.

Leora studies him for a moment longer, then her mouth quirks—not quite a smile, but something dangerously close to it.

“But also,” she adds, softer, “don’t stop being crude.”

He blinks.

She exhales through her nose, like she’s mildly amused at herself.

“It’s cute.”

That lands differently than anything else she’s said.

Chōbei goes still again, but this time it’s not alarm.

It’s recalibration.

His hand resumes in her hair—slower now, more deliberate, like he’s trying to decide whether he’s allowed to continue touching her in the same way after that word.

Leora doesn’t move away.

If anything, she shifts closer.

Her forehead presses lightly against his chest again, like she’s decided the conversation is over but not the contact.

Chōbei stares at the ceiling for a moment, then lets out a quiet, almost disbelieving breath.

“...You’re going to ruin me,” he murmurs.

Leora hums faintly, already half-drifting again.

“Too late.”

And this time, neither of them corrects the silence that follows.

The quiet doesn't last long.

It never really does with them—not like this, not when the weight between their bodies starts to feel safe enough that the mind decides it can afford to wander.

Leora shifts first.

Slowly, she pushes herself up from his chest, hair sliding over her shoulders as she turns to face him properly.

Chōbei instinctively adjusts with her, one hand still caught in her hair like he forgot it was there and is only now remembering he has to let go.

He doesn't.

Not fully.

His fingers stay tangled for a second too long before loosening.

Leora looks at him like she's studying something she already knows how to break.

And then she smiles.

It's small at first.

Almost soft.

Almost harmless.

But there's a tilt to it—something sharp tucked behind the gentleness, like the smile is only pretending to be polite.

Chōbei notices immediately.

His posture straightens a fraction without him meaning to.

“...What?” he asks carefully.

Leora tilts her head.

“Nothing,” she says, which is always a lie when she says it like that.

Her eyes move over him slowly, deliberately now. Not the way she looked at him before when she was collapsing into him—this is different. Awake. Curious. Patient in a way that feels slightly dangerous.

“You’re warm,” she adds casually.

Chōbei blinks.

“That’s... normal.”

“I know,” she says. “But you’re *consistently* warm.”

A pause.

Then, softer:

“It’s distracting.”

His brain visibly stalls.

“That’s not— that’s not something you say to someone.”

Leora hums like she’s considering this.

“Why not?”

“I—” he starts, then stops because there is no answer that doesn’t make him sound worse.

Leora’s smile widens slightly.

“Say it again,” she says.

Chōbei freezes.

“...What?”

“Tell me it’s not something you say.”

“I—Leora, you’re doing that on purpose.”

“Am I?”

Her eyes brighten in a way that makes him immediately regret having said anything at all.

She leans in just a little.

Not close enough to touch.

Close enough that he forgets where to put his hands.

“You’re very easy to read right now,” she says.

“I’m not—”

“Yes you are.”

Her voice drops slightly.

“Your ears go red before your thoughts catch up.”

Chōbei makes a sound that is halfway between protest and surrender.

“That’s not— I don’t do that.”

“You do.”

“I don’t.”

Leora’s expression turns faintly triumphant, like she’s won something she didn’t need but decided to take anyway.

“...You’re insufferable,” he mutters.

Her smile sharpens.

“That’s better,” she says. “Try again.”

Chōbei blinks.

“Try what.”

“Reacting.”

“I am reacting.”

“No,” she says lightly. “You’re surviving it.”

That lands.

He looks at her like he’s trying to decide whether to laugh or flee or both at the same time.

“You’re enjoying this,” he accuses.

“I always enjoy things,” she replies without hesitation.

“That’s not— that’s not helpful.”

Leora shifts closer again, just enough that his attention locks onto her fully whether he wants it to or not.

“Oh?” she says. “What would be helpful?”

Chōbei opens his mouth.

Closes it.

Opens it again.

Nothing comes out that won’t make things worse.

Leora watches him struggle for a moment, then her gaze softens in a way that makes the teasing feel almost merciful.

Almost.

Then she goes in again, quieter.

“You’re thinking too loudly,” she says.

“I’m not thinking loudly.”

“You are.”

“How do you even—”

“I can see it.”

That shuts him up.

Leora tilts her head again, studying him like she’s found something she didn’t expect to be interesting and is now mildly obsessed with the fact that it is.

Chōbei exhales.

“...You’re going to be the death of me,” he mutters.

Leora’s smile flickers.

“That would be inefficient,” she says.

And then, like she’s decided she’s pushed him far enough for now, she leans back slightly.

The air shifts with it.

Not lighter.

Heavier.

Like something is about to be said that isn't part of the game anymore.

Chōbei notices instantly.

His expression changes first.

"Leora," he says, quieter now. "What is it?"

She doesn't answer immediately.

Her gaze drops briefly to his chest, then to his hands, then back to his face like she's aligning something internally before she speaks.

The smile is gone now.

Not fully.

But buried.

"...The scars," she says.

Chōbei blinks.

"What about them?"

Leora's voice is steady.

"They're markings."

A pause.

"To tell which parts of me are which."

The room goes still in a way that is immediate and absolute.

Chōbei doesn't move.

Doesn't speak.

Doesn't even seem to breathe properly for a second.

"...What?" he says finally, but it comes out wrong. Too quiet. Too late.

Leora watches him carefully now, like she's already anticipating the impact but still has to say it anyway.

"In case I'm dismembered," she adds simply.

The silence that follows is not empty.

It's emptied.

Like something inside the room just stopped existing.

Chōbei's hand, still half-raised near her, lowers slowly without him realizing.

His voice, when it comes, is almost unrecognizable.

"...You're joking."

Leora doesn't answer right away.

Not yes.

Not no.

Just—

She watches him.

And that, somehow, is worse.

The warmth between them doesn't vanish.

But it changes shape.

No longer soft.

No longer playful.

Something held.

Something fragile in a way neither of them was prepared for a minute ago.

Chōbei's throat tightens.

"...Leora," he says again, but this time it's not a question.

It's a stop.

And for the first time since she started, Leora's expression loses its edge entirely.

Not softened.

Just... quieter.

Like she's already decided what comes after this reaction, and it isn't part of the game anymore.

The silence doesn't break immediately.

It just... shifts.

Like the room has to make space for what she just said before it can respond to it.

Chōbei doesn't speak right away.

His hand is still lowered now, resting somewhere between them on the bedding, like he forgot where it belongs.

Leora watches him for a moment longer, then exhales softly.

Not like she regrets saying it.

More like she's choosing the order in which to explain something that has always been true to her.

"You're not supposed to be able to see them," she says.

Chōbei's eyes lift slightly.

"...See them?"

"The scars," she clarifies.

A pause.

Then, quieter:

"Only Friedhelm can."

That name lands differently now.

Not sharp.

Not emotional.

Just... final.

Leora continues before he can interrupt.

“Not even Sukuna.”

Chōbei’s expression tightens in disbelief before he can stop it.

“That doesn’t make sense,” he says immediately.

“It does,” she replies simply.

Then, after a beat:

“It’s just not meant to.”

That makes him go still again.

Leora shifts slightly where she sits, drawing one knee up without thinking, arms resting loosely around it now as if she’s settling into explanation rather than retreating from it.

“You can,” she adds, looking at him now more directly. “Which is... actually beyond impressive.”

Chōbei blinks.

“That’s not— I didn’t do anything.”

“You did.”

Her gaze flickers briefly downward, then back up.

“But only because you were already open to it.”

A pause.

Then, more carefully:

“And when you touch me... it connects.”

Chōbei’s throat moves as he swallows.

“...Connects how.”

Leora exhales through her nose like she’s deciding how much of this to say.

“In the tribes,” she says finally, “children who can walk in death are baptized.”

The word *tribes* changes the air again.

Something older enters the room with it.

She doesn't look away when she continues.

"As infants. In the river of death."

Chōbei's hand twitches slightly.

Leora's voice stays steady.

"They're marked on the brow. A rune. And when they're brought back up—if they come back up—it becomes permanent."

Her eyes flick to him.

"And if you touch someone's brow and they carry the rune, you can read things. Not thoughts. Not exactly. But... truths. History. Intent."

Chōbei goes very still.

Leora continues anyway.

"It was used in the tribes to control people," she says. "To accuse them. To prove innocence. To decide what they were allowed to be."

A beat.

Her fingers tighten slightly around her knee.

"But it's dangerous. A lot of children don't come back from the baptism."

Silence settles again.

He doesn't interrupt.

She lets that continue.

"I never wanted my children to go through it," she says, quieter now. "So I never gave them that mark."

A pause.

Then, more carefully:

"If they don't have it... they can't see mine. Or any of the markings on my body."

Chōbei's eyes narrow slightly, trying to piece it together.

“...So your scars—”

She nods once.

“They're not just scars.”

Her voice flattens slightly, like she's forcing it to stay in the present tense.

“They're placement marks.”

Chōbei doesn't understand yet.

Not fully.

Leora sees that.

So she continues before he can get stuck in the wrong part of it.

“In case I'm dismembered.”

The room tightens again.

Harder this time.

Leora doesn't flinch.

“I need to know what belongs where,” she says. “What gets returned. What doesn't get left behind.”

Chōbei's breath stops halfway in.

The words *left behind* seem to land wrong in him.

He opens his mouth—

Closes it again.

Leora watches him carefully now.

Not testing.

Just observing what this costs him.

“That part,” she adds quietly, “is what most people react to.”

Chōbei's voice comes out rougher than before.

“...That’s not normal.”

Leora’s expression doesn’t change.

“No,” she agrees. “It isn’t.”

A beat.

Then she tilts her head slightly.

“If you had a mark,” she says, “you could see them too.”

Chōbei’s eyes lift sharply.

Leora continues, calm again.

“If you focused on the brow. The same way you do when you’re touching me.”

A pause.

Then, softer:

“But you don’t.”

Silence stretches.

Chōbei looks like he wants to say ten different things and can’t find a single one that doesn’t break something.

Leora exhales once.

Then adds, more quietly than everything before it:

“This stays between us.”

Leora is quiet for a moment after saying it stays between them.

Not tense anymore.

Just... thoughtful in a way that doesn’t fully belong in the present.

Her gaze drifts slightly to the side, unfocused for a beat too long, like she's looking at something that isn't in the room.

Then she exhales softly.

Her fingers begin to tap lightly against Chōbei's chest.

Not impatient.

Rhythmic.

Grounding herself more than him.

"...There's a family in the tribes," she says.

Chōbei doesn't interrupt.

Leora's voice changes slightly when she speaks about them—less guarded, more observant. Like she's describing something she's seen too many times to be surprised by anymore.

"The Karskov."

The name carries weight in her mouth.

Not reverence.

Recognition.

"They're terrifying," she adds, after a pause. "But... consistent. That might be the worst part of them."

Chōbei's hand shifts slightly near her waist, but he doesn't speak.

Leora continues.

"They believe power is only real when it's used. If something dies, it's not gone. It's just... redistributed."

Her fingers pause briefly on his chest, then resume tapping.

"On battlefields, they don't just take weapons," she says. "They take everything. Bone. Teeth. Tendons. Breath, if they can capture it before it fades."

A faint, almost absent smile touches her mouth.

"It's not uncommon to see someone's kin in their home afterward," she says. "Not as remembrance."

A beat.

“As furniture. As instruments. As tools.”

Chōbei’s expression tightens slightly, but he still doesn’t speak.

Leora’s gaze lowers, watching her own fingers move against him like she’s checking whether the memory is stable enough to continue holding.

“They make music from bones,” she says. “Not metaphorically. Literally.”

Her voice stays steady.

“Wind instruments from ribs. Percussion from skull plates. Strings from tendons. They say it keeps the dead useful.”

A pause.

Then, softer:

“And if it can be used... it should be.”

Chōbei exhales quietly through his nose, something between discomfort and disbelief.

Leora notices, but doesn’t stop.

“Their marks are messy,” she adds. “Not clean like formal rites. They don’t believe in refinement. Every time they take something—every time they repurpose something—they add another layer.”

Her hand lifts slightly, gesturing faintly in the air as if drawing it out.

“Jagged. Overlapping. Like accumulation instead of identity.”

Her eyes flick briefly toward Chōbei.

“Teeth marks. Bone fragments. Carved notches. Proof of everything they’ve taken and survived.”

A beat.

“They don’t hide it,” she says. “They display it.”

Her voice dips slightly.

“Your last words aren’t yours in Karskov homes,” she says. “They’re stored. Broken down. Used later if they’re useful.”

Chōbei's hand tightens faintly at her side now, but still he doesn't interrupt.

Leora continues, quieter now.

"Memories too," she says. "They can take them apart. Rebuild them into something else. Something functional."

A pause.

"Even love," she adds after a moment, "gets stripped down until it becomes something you can use."

Silence settles heavier between them.

Her fingers stop tapping for the first time.

Then resume again, slower.

"...They're not allowed to take my parts," she says.

Chōbei looks at her more sharply now.

Leora doesn't look back immediately.

When she does, her expression is calm—but there's something underneath it that is not about the Karskov anymore.

"Not because I'm protected," she continues. "Because it would make them dangerous in ways even they don't want to deal with."

A faint, almost humorless exhale leaves her.

"If they had access to my body the way they do with others," she says, "they wouldn't just be repurposing death anymore."

Her eyes meet his again.

"They'd be making something that doesn't stay controlled."

A pause.

Then, much softer, like she's stepping away from that line before it becomes too real even for her:

"So they don't touch me."

Her fingers finally still against his chest.

The room is quiet again, but not empty.

Just... heavier.

Chōbei looks at her for a long moment, like he's trying to decide what part of that he's allowed to feel first.

Then, carefully:

"...That's not a culture," he says quietly. "That's a way of making the world not belong to anyone anymore."

Leora watches him for a beat.

Then her expression shifts slightly—something almost approving.

"Yeah," she says simply.

A pause.

Then, quieter still:

"That's why they survive."

Leora watches him for a moment after she finishes speaking about the Karskov.

Not assessing him.

Just waiting.

Like she's giving him space to decide what kind of silence he wants to exist in.

Chōbei doesn't move at first.

His hand is still near her, but it feels like he's suddenly aware of it in a way he wasn't before. Like it belongs to him again in a way that's slightly uncomfortable.

Leora shifts closer without asking.

Gently, she takes his hand.

Chōbei lets her.

She turns it over in her palm like she's checking for something invisible, then presses a kiss to the center of it.

Once.

Then to his fingers.

Slow.

Unhurried.

Not performative.

Just... deliberate contact, like she's grounding something that has started to drift too far away from them both.

Chōbei sits completely still while she does it.

Like moving would break the moment in a way he doesn't know how to repair.

When she's done, she doesn't let go immediately.

Her thumb rests lightly against his knuckles.

"You have questions," she says softly.

It isn't a question.

It's an opening.

Chōbei's throat tightens slightly.

He looks at her hand holding his, then at her face.

Something in his expression wavers—less certainty now, more weight than he knows where to put.

"I—" he starts, then stops.

He exhales.

"...I feel sick," he admits quietly.

Leora doesn't react sharply to that.

Just watches him.

Not surprised.

Not offended.

Present.

A long pause stretches between them.

Then Chōbei shifts slightly, like something inside him has decided what it needs more than comfort.

“...Stay,” he says.

Leora blinks once.

“With you?” she asks.

He nods immediately, like if he waits too long the answer will become something else.

“Tonight,” he adds. Then, after a beat, quieter: “Tomorrow too.”

Leora studies him for a moment.

Then her expression softens in a way that feels less like gentleness and more like agreement settling into place.

“...Yes,” she says simply.

Chōbei exhales like something in him finally drops.

“Okay,” he says.

A pause.

Then his hand turns slightly in hers, not pulling away, just grounding himself more firmly in the contact.

His voice lowers.

“...I want to know.”

Leora watches him closely now.

Chōbei’s jaw tightens once.

“No,” he corrects himself, more firmly this time, like he’s forcing the words into alignment with something deeper.

“I need to know.”

That lands differently.

Leora's thumb stills on his knuckle.

For a moment, she just looks at him—like she's measuring how much of him is steady and how much is about to break open.

Then she nods once.

Quiet.

Accepting.

"Alright," she says.

Silence settles again.

Not avoidance this time.

Preparation.

Chōbei holds her hand a little tighter without realizing it.

And then, finally, he speaks again.

"...Tell me about the Ten Brinkens."

Leora makes a small sound—almost a huff, almost amusement—before shifting again without asking.

Chōbei doesn't get time to adjust before she's moving with intent rather than hesitation, sliding herself into the space between his legs like it was always meant to be arranged that way.

It changes the angle of everything.

The room, his breathing, the way his body remembers how to exist.

She settles in fully, back against him, comfortably anchored. One hand comes to rest over his chest, right above his heart, fingers moving in a slow, absent pattern—feeling, not pressing. Like she's checking that he's still there without needing to confirm it verbally.

Her other hand drifts to his side, tracing lightly over the scars there.

Not avoiding them.

Acknowledging them.

Then she reaches up, catches part of his braid, and gently starts to toy with it like she's decided it belongs in her hands now.

A small, soft smile curves her mouth.

"You're really so cute," she says.

Chōbei stops breathing.

It isn't dramatic.

It's immediate.

Like his body forgets the instruction.

Leora doesn't notice—or pretends not to. Her fingers keep moving against his chest in a steady rhythm, grounding herself more than him.

And then she begins.

Her voice shifts slightly. Not louder. Not formal.

Just... anchored.

Like she is stepping into something she has spoken through before.

"The Ten Brinken," she says.

The name sits differently in her mouth than the others.

Not heavy like the Karskov.

Not cold like a warning.

Structured.

Ancient in a way that feels organized rather than decayed.

"Germanic," she adds, almost idly. "It means 'at the brink.' Those who stand at the threshold."

Chōbei's hand lifts slightly—uncertain where to go—but he doesn't interrupt.

Leora continues, her fingers still moving over his chest like she's keeping time with something only she can hear.

“They don’t believe in distance from death,” she says. “They believe in proximity as authority.”

A pause.

Then, softer:

“To stand at the edge is to command what’s on the other side.”

Chōbei swallows.

Leora shifts her shoulders slightly against him, settling deeper into the contact as if this is the most natural place in the world for this explanation to happen.

“They are born in pairs,” she says.

A beat.

“Not twins. Bound siblings.”

Her thumb presses lightly against his sternum as she speaks, almost absent-minded.

“One son. One daughter.”

Her voice lowers slightly.

“The son becomes the head. Authority. Voice. Command.”

Her hand stills for half a second.

Then resumes.

“And the daughter...”

A pause that lasts just long enough to feel deliberate.

“...the Alraune.”

Chōbei’s fingers twitch slightly near her waist.

Leora doesn’t look up at him.

Not yet.

“She isn’t a role,” she says quietly. “Not like a title you inherit. It’s more like... a condition. A way of existing at the edge of things.”

Her tone tightens slightly—not with emotion, but precision.

“Where the others stand at the brink,” she says, “she is tied to it.”

A breath.

“Rooted in it.”

Chōbei’s chest rises and falls unevenly beneath her hand.

Leora continues.

“Their power is sound.”

That lands differently.

Her fingers move slightly against his chest, as if illustrating without meaning to.

“Voice. Chant. Song. Breath. Even silence when it’s controlled correctly.”

A faint exhale leaves her.

“To them, sound is not expression,” she says. “It is command.”

Chōbei’s hand tightens faintly at her side.

Leora doesn’t stop.

“They can change movement,” she continues. “Stillness. Memory. The space between intention and action.”

A pause.

“And sometimes,” she adds more quietly, “the boundary between life and death itself.”

The room feels smaller now.

Not physically.

But perceptually.

Like everything inside it is listening more carefully than before.

Leora’s fingers drift upward slightly, brushing near his braid again as if she’s forgotten she’s doing it.

“They walk the threshold very well,” she says. “That’s what makes them dangerous. Not because they cross it—but because they understand it without hesitation.”

Chōbei’s voice finally breaks through, low and strained.

“...And you?”

Leora is quiet for a moment.

Her hand over his heart stills completely.

Then she answers.

“I don’t walk it,” she says.

A pause.

“I’m tied to it.”

The words sit there without embellishment.

Then, softer—almost reluctantly:

“That’s why I was given a Binder.”

Chōbei’s brow tightens slightly.

“A what?”

Leora’s gaze flickers down for the first time, like she’s deciding how much of this memory she wants to open.

“Assigned when I was a child,” she says. “Someone to anchor me.”

A beat.

“They grow up with you. First as playmate. Then as guard. Then...” her voice pauses slightly, “as something between protection and restraint.”

Chōbei goes still again.

Leora exhales quietly.

“It depends on the Ten Brinken,” she adds. “Whether they call it loyalty or containment.”

Her fingers resume their slow movement against his chest, but less certain now.

Chōbei looks down at her—really looks—and something in his expression shifts.

Not fear.

Not shock.

Something heavier.

Understanding trying not to become anger.

Leora doesn't look up.

But her voice softens slightly when she continues.

"Their voices..." she says, "can stop you before you realize you were going to move."

A faint, almost distant expression crosses her face.

"Not because they're loud," she adds.

A pause.

"Because the world listens."

Silence settles between them again.

But this time, it isn't empty.

It's occupied.

By the shape of everything she just didn't say.

Leora makes a soft sound under her breath—half a huff, half amusement—before shifting again without asking.

Chōbei barely has time to register it before she's moving into him, not away.

She turns fully this time, settling herself between his legs facing him, close enough that there is no angle where she isn't directly in his space. Not pressed back into him anymore—present with him. Intentional.

It changes everything about the silence.

Her hands come up immediately.

One settles over his chest, right above his heart, fingers moving in a slow, absent rhythm as if she's grounding herself through him. The other lifts to his face without hesitation, brushing lightly along the right side—over the scars there, tracing them with something careful and familiar.

Then she toys with his braid again, like she's claimed the motion for herself.

Her expression softens into something dangerously pleased.

"You really are so cute," she says again, like it's an established fact she keeps confirming for herself.

Chōbei doesn't respond.

He looks like he's trying to remember how.

Leora watches that happen in real time, and it makes her smile sharpen slightly—not cruelly, but with interest.

Her thumb presses lightly into his chest.

Then she adds, quieter, almost like she didn't mean to say it out loud:

"I have to remember how to breathe when I look at you."

That lands.

Not like impact.

Like interruption.

Chōbei's hand twitches near her shoulder, then stills again as if he's afraid movement will break whatever this is becoming.

Leora doesn't give him space to recover.

She exhales slowly and leans in just slightly, still holding his gaze, still holding him in place with nothing but proximity.

Then she begins.

"The Ten Brinken," she says.

And the way she says it is different now.

Not explanation.

Recognition.

Her own name inside a shared history.

"My family."

Her fingers continue moving over his chest, but now it's less grounding and more instinctive—like she's tracing memory through touch.

"We are called 'those at the brink,'" she says quietly. "Not because we approach death."

A pause.

"Because we stand in it."

Her hand lifts briefly to his face again, brushing over the scarred side of his cheek like she's aligning something only she can see.

Chōbei doesn't move away.

He can't tell if he's allowed to.

Leora continues.

"We're born in pairs," she says. "Always."

Her eyes stay on his as she speaks, unblinking now.

"A son. And a daughter."

A faint exhale leaves her nose, almost like irritation at how simple it sounds when she says it out loud.

"The sons become voice," she says. "Command. Authority. The part that tells the world what it's allowed to do."

Her thumb presses slightly into his chest again.

"And the daughters..."

Her gaze tightens just a fraction.

"...become the Alraune."

That word shifts something in her expression. Not pride. Not softness.

Something heavier.

Personal.

"I am one," she says simply.

No performance in it.

Just fact.

Her hand stills on his chest for a moment, then resumes more slowly.

“It’s not a title,” she adds. “It’s what happens when you don’t belong to distance anymore. When you don’t separate yourself from what’s happening at the edge of things.”

A pause.

Her voice lowers slightly.

“I don’t walk the brink like the others,” she says.

Her fingers tighten once, briefly.

“I’m tied to it.”

Chōbei’s breath catches slightly, but he doesn’t interrupt.

Leora watches him register that.

Then continues anyway.

“Our power is sound,” she says.

A beat.

“Voice. Breath. Song. Command spoken or half-spoken.”

Her thumb traces lightly along his chest in a slow arc.

“To us, sound isn’t expression. It’s instruction.”

Her eyes flick briefly to his lips, then back up.

“It changes movement,” she says. “Stillness. What people think they decided on their own.”

A faint, humorless exhale.

“And sometimes,” she adds, quieter, “what they were going to become.”

The room feels smaller again.

Not because it is.

Because she is filling it with something older than it.

Chōbei's hand finally moves, slowly, hesitantly, settling over her wrist where she's touching his chest—not stopping her, just anchoring himself to the fact that she's real.

Leora notices.

Doesn't pull away.

Instead, she tilts her head slightly, watching him more closely now.

"You're still listening," she says softly.

Chōbei swallows.

"I said I needed to know," he answers.

Leora's smile returns—smaller now. Less sharp.

More certain.

"Good," she says.

Her hand brushes his cheek again, slower this time, lingering over the scars on the right side like she's memorizing them.

Then she adds, almost absent-mindedly:

"You'd hate the way they teach it."

A pause.

Then, softer:

"And I think you'd still listen anyway."

Her gaze holds his.

Close.

Unmoving.

And for a moment, neither of them speaks—because whatever this is, it has stopped feeling like explanation.

And started feeling like inheritance.

Leora's fingers slow in his hair.

Not because she is uncertain.

Because something in the memory she is pulling up makes her quieter in a way that doesn't match her tone.

Her thumb brushes the end of his braid, turning it once, like she is checking something she already knows by heart.

"You really are so cute," she says again, softer this time, like it's a fact she keeps rediscovering. Then she exhales through her nose, almost annoyed at herself. "I have to remember how to breathe when I look at you."

Chōbei gives a small, helpless sound like his lungs forgot their job.

Leora smiles at that. Not teasing now—fond. Anchored.

Then she taps lightly against his chest again, right over his heartbeat, as if she is listening to something under the skin.

"The Ten Brinken don't really have... childhoods the way people think of them," she says.

Her gaze drifts briefly to the side—past him, past the room—like she is looking at a place that still exists even if it shouldn't.

"We have training that pretends to be childhood."

Her fingers slide up his chest, slow, absentminded, like she is mapping a familiar shape.

"I was paired young," she continues. "Not like siblings. Not like friends. More like... resonance. You don't get to choose the voice that answers you. It just becomes the one that does."

Her hand pauses at his collarbone.

"You learn early that sound isn't for comfort. It's for control."

A faint smile tugs at her mouth, but it doesn't reach her eyes yet.

"And then you learn the difference between speaking and making something obey you."

She leans in slightly as she says it, close enough that her breath touches him before her words fully land.

Chōbei's hand tightens in her hair without him meaning to.

Leora notices. Of course she notices.

She looks at him like that matters.

"It's not dramatic when you grow up in it," she says. "It's normal. Like learning how to walk."

Then, almost gently:

"And Friedhelm... he learned it the same way I did."

That name changes the air, but she doesn't let it become heavy. She just keeps going, steadying it with her voice.

Her fingers drift to the side of his face now, right where the scars gather near his braid. Not avoiding them. Not tracing them carefully either—just touching them as if they are part of him the same way everything else is.

"In the Ten Brinken, markings aren't decoration," she says. "They're instruction."

Her nail lightly catches one of the older lines in his skin.

"Voice markers. Breath control points. Places the body remembers how to obey."

She tilts her head slightly, studying him with a strange softness.

"You don't have them," she murmurs. "But your body... it reacts like it recognizes them anyway."

A faint huff of amusement escapes her again, but it's quieter now.

"Of course you would be like that."

Her hand shifts back into his hair, loosening his braid a little without asking permission, letting it fall slightly uneven against his shoulder.

"That braid," she says, almost conversational now, "is very Ten Brinken of you, you know."

Then she smiles properly this time, and it lands more dangerously because it's warm.

"You're controlled in ways you don't even realize."

Her thumb traces once over his temple.

"And soft in ways you keep pretending you aren't."

She leans in just enough that her forehead almost brushes his.

"And I have to remember how to breathe when I look at you," she repeats, like she's mildly offended by it, like it's a weakness she refuses to acknowledge as one.

Chōbei's breath stutters again, worse this time, because she's still looking at him like she's telling the truth.

And then she adds, quieter—almost like she forgot she was supposed to be careful:

“The Ten Brinken used to say sound belongs to whoever can survive hearing it.”

A pause.

Her fingers still in his hair.

“But I think they were wrong.”

Another pause.

Her voice drops just slightly.

“I think it belongs to whoever you can't stop listening to.”

And she stays there, between his legs, holding him like she forgot the idea of distance existed at all.

Chōbei moves suddenly.

Not violently.

Desperately.

One arm hooks around her waist and pulls her forward until she lands fully in his lap, the motion rough enough to steal the breath from her chest.

Leora gasps softly.

And before she can tease him for it, he buries his face against her neck.

Not kissing.

Not speaking.

Just breathing her in like proximity is the only thing keeping something inside him steady.

His hands flatten hard against her back, fingers spreading like he needs proof she is actually here.

Leora goes very still.

Then slowly—very slowly—her expression changes.

Softens.

Something deep in her unwinds at the feeling of being held like that.

Not delicately.

Not carefully.

Possessively.

Like he needs her closer than the world is currently allowing.

Chōbei finally pulls back a little, breath uneven.

Leora looks down at him.

Then she smiles.

Small.

Warm.

Achingly sincere.

“Thank you,” she says quietly.

Chōbei blinks up at her, still holding her tightly around the waist.

“For what?”

Her fingers brush back through his hair near the braid she loosened earlier.

“For bringing me closer to your beauty.”

He chokes.

Actually chokes.

A horrified sound escapes him while his entire face burns red instantly.

Leora’s smile widens with unmistakable delight.

“There it is,” she murmurs fondly. “That reaction is my favorite.”

“Stop saying things like that,” he manages hoarsely.

“No.”

Immediate.

Bright.

Completely unrepentant.

She shifts more comfortably in his lap, one knee sliding against the bedding beside his hip while her hands settle against his shoulders.

Then her expression quiets again.

Not colder.

Older.

“The Ten Brinken care very much about bloodlines,” she says. “Enough that it poisons almost everything.”

Chōbei’s arms tighten slightly around her.

She notices.

Continues anyway.

“Power is inherited most cleanly through direct lineage, so pure-blooded children are trained almost immediately. Breath discipline first. Silence second. Voice control third.”

A faint huff leaves her.

“You learn how to stand before you learn how to speak properly.”

Chōbei immediately thinks of Friedhelm.

The impossible posture.

The rigid stillness.

The way every movement looked measured even during violence.

Then he thinks of Tsukihiko.

Kurohiko.

Kaguya.

Even Mizuki.

All upright.

All controlled.

Something uncomfortable settles in his chest.

Leora watches realization move across his face and smiles slightly.

“Yes,” she says softly. “Now you see it.”

Her fingers slide absently into her own hair as she speaks.

“The hair matters too. Long hair trains breath control. Weight. Posture. Rhythm.” A pause.
“You’re taught never to move it carelessly.”

Chōbei suddenly remembers Friedhelm’s tidy short locks.

Not casual.

Controlled.

Every strand intentional.

He remembers how often Leora braids her hair before speaking seriously or fighting.

Not habit.

Training.

The realization shifts something fundamental about the way he sees both of them.

Leora studies his expression carefully, clearly amused by how many things are rearranging themselves in his head at once.

“Occasionally,” she continues, “someone appears far outside the direct family with overwhelming ability. A distant descendant. An accident in the bloodline.”

Her voice lowers slightly.

“That tends to make the hierarchy... unstable.”

She says it lightly, but something beneath it sharpens.

“As the Alraune, I was different from the others even before my abilities matured.”

Chōbei's gaze lifts back to her face immediately.

Leora's fingers drift along the back of his neck now, soothing him without seeming aware she's doing it.

"The others walk close to death," she says quietly. "The Alraune becomes entangled with it."

The room feels smaller suddenly.

Still.

"She is assigned a Gegner as a child."

Chōbei frowns slightly.

"A binder," Leora explains. "Someone raised beside her from childhood onward."

Her gaze unfocuses slightly as she speaks.

"Playmate first."

A pause.

"Then bodyguard."

Another pause.

"Then jailer, if necessary."

The words settle heavily between them.

Chōbei thinks suddenly of Friedhelm standing behind her during the fight.

The way he moved around her like instinct.

The way she never once seemed afraid of him despite the brutality.

Or perhaps because of it.

Leora continues before he can ask anything.

"The Ten Brinken are known most for their voices," she says. "But axes are our oldest discipline."

A faint smile returns.

"Friedhelm is the best axe master the family has produced in over six hundred years."

She says it the way someone might comment on weather.

Completely matter-of-fact.

Chōbei stares at her.

“That’s not normal.”

“No,” she agrees easily. “It isn’t.”

Her fingers brush once over his jaw.

“The duel axes are traditional. Voice techniques support them. Chants. Amplification. Direction through resonance.”

Chōbei thinks about the domain.

About their voices overlapping while stone shattered beneath them.

His stomach twists.

Leora notices that too.

She always notices.

So she leans down and presses a soft kiss beside the scars on his face.

Not distracting him.

Rewarding him for staying.

When she pulls back, he’s still staring at her with that overwhelmed, breathless expression she seems to enjoy far too much.

Then finally, after a long silence, he asks quietly:

“Who was your Gegner?”

Leora stills.

Leora stills so completely that for a moment Chōbei thinks she has stopped breathing.

The warmth leaves her expression first.

Then the playfulness.

Then even the careful composure she usually keeps wrapped around herself like silk.

What remains underneath looks—

broken.

Not dramatically.

Not visibly shattered.

Just exhausted in some ancient, irreversible way.

Her fingers curl slightly against his shoulders.

“Chōbei,” she says quietly, “you really won’t repeat these things?”

The question is so serious it makes his chest tighten immediately.

Her eyes search his face with something dangerously close to fear.

“Can I really trust you with things that are dangerous to know?”

She swallows.

“Because once you see them...” Her voice lowers. “You can’t unsee them.”

A tremor moves through her hands.

“The ugliness. The contradictions.”

Chōbei feels her shaking now where she sits in his lap.

Tiny.

Contained.

But real.

And somehow that is far worse than if she had fallen apart completely.

Leora looks away from him sharply, jaw tightening.

“I don’t even know if I can say certain things anymore,” she admits. “Every word always reaches someone eventually.”

Her laugh this time is awful.

Small.

Humorless.

“Everything gets back to Sukuna.”

Chōbei goes still.

Not because he thinks Sukuna is listening.

Because he suddenly understands she means something much larger than that.

Leora presses the heel of her hand briefly against her forehead.

“He could be listening right now,” she mutters. “Or hear it later. Or hear a distorted version from someone else. It doesn’t matter. It always comes back eventually.”

Her breathing turns uneven.

“That’s how I learned not to speak carelessly.”

Her gaze unfocuses somewhere past him.

“You learn very young that idle words become evidence. That affection becomes leverage. That grief becomes weakness.” Her mouth tightens. “So eventually you start speaking as if you’ll have to answer for every sentence later.”

Chōbei feels something cold move through him.

Not horror.

Magnitude.

The sheer size of what that must have done to someone over a lifetime.

Suddenly so many things about her rearrange themselves inside his head.

The precision of her words.

The way she listens before answering.

The way she reveals things in pieces instead of wholes.

The way affection from her sometimes feels carefully chosen instead of impulsive.

Not manipulation.

Survival.

Leora looks back at him then, frustrated suddenly, eyes bright with unshed tears she clearly hates having.

“It’s exhausting sometimes,” she says, voice cracking slightly despite herself.

The honesty of it lands harder than anything else she has said.

Because she sounds angry about being tired.

Not ashamed.

Not self-pitying.

Just tired.

And that feels infinitely more real.

She laughs once under her breath and wipes roughly at one eye before anything can fall.

“I have Friedhelm,” she says quietly. “I always will.”

The words come quickly, instinctively.

Like a reflex.

But then her expression twists.

“Sometimes things are too close to both of us.”

Her fingers tighten painfully in the fabric near Chōbei’s shoulder.

“He’s my brother.”

The sentence sounds fragile.

“He’s...” She exhales shakily. “He’s carrying things because of me.”

Chōbei immediately starts to object, but she keeps going before he can.

“And sometimes I think—”

She stops.

Her throat works once.

Then finally:

“Sometimes I wish I had just died.”

The room goes completely still.

“So he could have had a better life.”

Chōbei feels the words hit him physically.

Like something heavy slammed into his ribs.

Leora’s face turns away immediately after saying it, like she already regrets letting it exist outside her head.

But her body stays in his lap.

Still holding onto him.

Still shaking faintly.

As if some part of her trusted him enough to break anyway.

Leora presses the heels of her hands briefly against her eyes.

Not to hide.

To steady herself.

When she lowers them again, her gaze is distant in a way Chōbei has never seen before. Not unfocused.

Entrenched.

Like she is speaking from somewhere very far away and very deep underground.

“Every word is a choice,” she says quietly.

The trembling in her voice is gone now.

That almost makes it worse.

“And every choice becomes a consequence.”

Her fingers tighten once against his shoulders.

“And every consequence must be owned. Answered. Witnessed.”

The words come too smoothly.

Not rehearsed.

Conditioned.

Chōbei realizes with a sick feeling that this is not philosophy to her.

It is infrastructure.

Something built into her bones young enough that she no longer notices it holding her upright.

Leora lets out a slow breath.

“That’s why becoming hollow stops being a tragedy after a while.” Her eyes flick toward him briefly. “It becomes necessary.”

Chōbei’s chest tightens painfully.

She sees it happen.

Of course she does.

But she continues anyway.

“Friedhelm and I...” She pauses, jaw tightening slightly. “We can either feel everything—every fear, every memory, every contradiction—or we can cut away everything except the language you saw in the domain.”

Her voice lowers.

“Because that language makes sense to us.”

The room feels colder suddenly.

“That language was rewarded.”

Not pride.

Not shame.

Just fact.

“To speak through violence was holy.”

Chōbei feels her shift slightly in his lap, not moving away from him but curling inward for a fraction of a second before forcing herself still again.

“And the awful part,” she says softly, almost smiling now in a way that makes something twist in his stomach, “is that the people who wanted to hear that language...”

Her eyes finally meet his fully again.

“...never realized what we were actually saying underneath it.”

The satisfaction in her expression is wrong somehow.

Not cruel.

Vindicated.

Like she and Friedhelm survived by hiding entire conversations beneath blood and brutality while everyone around them applauded the violence and missed the meaning completely.

Chōbei suddenly understands why the fight in the domain felt intimate in ways he could not explain.

Why it disturbed him more than the damage itself.

They had not just been hurting each other.

They had been speaking.

And no one else in the room had truly understood the language.

Leora watches realization strike him and something in her expression softens despite herself.

Then hardens again almost immediately after.

Like softness is dangerous if held too long.

She swallows once.

Then asks quietly:

“Do you really want to know who my Gegner was?”

This time the question lands differently.

Not warning him away.

Preparing him for impact.

Leora's gaze drops to his chest again.

To the rise and fall of his breathing beneath her hand.

She watches it for a long moment before speaking again, quieter now, but somehow even more intense because of it.

"Every word is a choice," she says.

Her fingers move once against him unconsciously, almost keeping rhythm with the sentence.

"And every choice becomes a consequence."

Another small movement.

"And every consequence must be owned."

A pause.

"Answered."

Another.

"Witnessed."

Chōbei feels each word settle into her like old scar tissue.

Not beliefs.

Conditioning.

Something repeated until it became indistinguishable from instinct.

Leora exhales slowly through her nose and closes her eyes for half a second.

"That's why becoming hollow eventually stops feeling sad."

When she opens them again, there's no self-pity in her expression.

Only exhaustion.

"It becomes necessary."

The room feels impossibly quiet around them.

She shifts slightly in his lap, one hand still resting over his heart while the other lightly traces the scars on the side of his face.

“Friedhelm and I can either feel all of it,” she says softly. “Every memory. Every fear. Every ugly thing that still lives underneath our skin...”

Her mouth tightens faintly.

“Or we cut everything away except the language you saw in the domain.”

Chōbei’s arms tighten around her instinctively.

She notices.

Keeps speaking anyway.

“Because we understand that language.”

Her eyes drift somewhere far away again.

“That language was rewarded.”

The words land with terrifying simplicity.

“To speak through violence was holy.”

Chōbei feels something cold twist low in his stomach.

Not because of the brutality.

Because of the reverence in the sentence.

Not admiration.

Recognition.

Leora leans her forehead briefly against his shoulder, voice quieter now.

“When we fought like that...” she murmurs, “they listened.”

A small laugh escapes her then.

Soft.

Wrong.

Touched with something almost feverishly satisfied.

“And the strangest part is...” She lifts her head again slowly, eyes glinting faintly. “The people who wanted to hear that language never noticed what we were actually saying underneath it.”

Chōbei stills.

Completely.

Because suddenly the domain rearranges itself in his memory.

The chants.

The overlapping voices.

The impossible synchronization.

The violence that had felt far too intimate to simply be combat.

They had not just been hurting each other.

They had been communicating through the only language they had ever been rewarded for speaking fluently.

And everyone watching had mistaken the conversation for savagery.

Leora sees the realization hit him.

Something in her expression loosens.

Not relief.

Recognition.

Like he finally stepped close enough to see the shape of the wound instead of just the blood around it.

Her thumb brushes once against the edge of his jaw.

And for the first time since she started speaking, she looks tired enough to collapse.

Chōbei does not interrupt her again after she asks if he really wants to know.

He keeps one arm around her waist instead, holding her in his lap with a kind of careful firmness that feels less like restraint and more like anchoring. His other hand stays against her back beneath the heavy spill of her hair.

Leora sits very still for a while after that.

Too still.

The candlelight catches along her throat when she swallows.

Outside, somewhere deeper in the estate, wind moves through the corridors with a low hollow sound. Chōbei can hear distant footsteps. Guards changing posts. The soft creak of old timber.

Life continuing.

And somehow that makes the room feel smaller.

Leora looks down at his chest instead of at him.

Then quietly:

“Who told you about Wulf?”

Chōbei’s fingers flex once against her waist.

“Friedhelm.”

That makes something unreadable move across her face.

Not surprise.

Something sadder.

“He said his name?”

“He said enough.”

A long silence settles after that.

Then Leora finally speaks.

“Wulf knew me before I became useful to anyone.”

The words land softly.

Too softly for how heavy they are.

“He grew up with Friedhelm and me.”

Her fingers tap once against Chōbei's shoulder absently, like she is following memory instead of thought.

"Most people thought he was our father's bastard."

A pause.

"He wasn't."

Her mouth curves faintly.

"But by then it hardly mattered."

Chōbei watches her carefully.

There is no performance in her now.

No flirtation.

No teasing.

Just excavation.

"Friedhelm and Wulf loved each other like brothers," she says quietly. "They were together constantly. If one of them was missing, the other was usually close enough to hear."

The image settles immediately in Chōbei's mind without permission:

Friedhelm younger. Wulf beside him. Leora somewhere between them.

Three children raised inside something brutal enough to make closeness feel like survival.

"Friedhelm wanted to leave long before I did," she continues.

"But Wulf didn't."

Her eyes drift toward the darkened window.

"He loved the Alraune."

That catches in Chōbei strangely.

Not because the statement is romantic.

Because of how sincere it sounds.

"He thought he could survive inside it without becoming cruel."

Her voice lowers further.

“He would not let them turn me into something broken.”

Chōbei’s jaw tightens.

Leora notices.

Of course she notices.

“He told Friedhelm he would never rape me.”

The room goes still.

“Never strike me.”

Another pause.

“Never make our children afraid of him.”

Chōbei feels sick.

Not because he doubts her.

Because of how plainly she says it.

Like those promises had once been extraordinary.

“So Friedhelm relented,” she says softly.

And suddenly Chōbei understands something awful:

Friedhelm had not trusted the world.

He had trusted Wulf.

Leora’s fingers stop moving.

“There was a culling.”

No flourish.

No dramatics.

Just fact.

“Lone survivor.”

The candle pops softly beside the bed.

Chōbei does not speak.

Leora's eyes unfocus slightly.

"Wulf left before dawn."

And now memory sharpens around her without her meaning it to.

"We were still in bed when he said it."

Chōbei stills.

Leora gives a small breath through her nose.

"He almost never spoke."

A pause.

"Not about things like that."

Then quieter:

"But that morning he held me and told me he loved me."

The words feel almost disbelieving even now.

Like part of her still exists in that room hearing it for the first time.

"Friedhelm heard him."

Chōbei can almost see it.

Cold morning light.

Shared quarters.

Friedhelm nearby, half dressed, hearing something so rare it became immortal instantly.

"Wulf looked at him afterward and sat up."

Leora's voice turns distant.

"He took my wrist."

Her fingers curl unconsciously against Chōbei's chest.

“He told me he was going to win.”

A small pause.

“And when we married, Friedhelm would live with us.”

Chōbei closes his eyes briefly.

Because that line destroys everything.

Not fantasy.

Not desperation.

A future.

Planned carefully enough to include all three of them.

Wulf assumed survival.

Assumed time.

Assumed hope.

Leora’s throat moves again.

“He did win.”

Silence.

“I watched him walk out of the field.”

Now her voice sounds almost detached from her body.

“Covered in blood.”

“Mud.”

“Human filth.”

“Rainwater.”

Her eyes lower.

“The ravens were screaming.”

The image settles heavy and complete between them.

“And I was happy,” she whispers.

A tiny pause.

“For one moment, I thought everything would be all right.”

Chōbei’s arm tightens around her instinctively.

Leora laughs once under her breath.

Not amusement.

Something sharp and exhausted.

“My father changed the terms before Wulf had even finished standing.”

The bitterness in that sentence is old enough to feel fossilized.

“He promised me to another man.”

Chōbei feels her pulse jumping beneath his hand now.

Fast.

Uneven.

“I felt the tender part of me stop hoping.”

The way she says it hurts worse than if she cried.

Because it sounds like realization.

Not grief.

“Within the hour, Friedhelm took me away.”

And suddenly Chōbei understands everything differently.

Friedhelm had not stolen her from Wulf.

He had taken her away after hope collapsed.

After the world proved Wulf could not protect her from it.

Even though he had tried.

Even though he had survived.

Chōbei speaks before he fully means to.

“Wulf never got the chance to choose.”

Leora’s eyes close briefly.

“No.”

The word barely exists.

Then after a long silence:

“Neither did Friedhelm.”

The room goes quiet after that.

Not empty.

Heavy.

Three people losing each other all at once across the same day.

Wulf losing Leora.

Friedhelm losing Wulf.

Leora losing the future all three of them thought they were building together.

And suddenly Chōbei understands something else too:

The escape was not freedom.

It was what came after hope died.

Leora finally looks back at him then.

Small.

Tired.

Terrifyingly open.

And Chōbei realizes with a kind of painful certainty that she has almost never told this story aloud exactly as it happened.

Not because she forgot.

Because remembering it properly is unbearable.

Chōbei sits with the silence for a long time after she finishes.

His hand stays at the back of her neck.

Thumb moving once occasionally against her skin like he is reassuring himself she is still there.

Leora does not move away from him.

For once, she almost seems tired of holding herself upright.

The candles have burned lower now.

Their room feels softer around the edges.

Too soft for the things they are talking about.

Chōbei finally speaks quietly.

“What about Sukuna?”

Leora’s lashes lower slightly.

Not avoidance.

Consideration.

“What about him?”

Chōbei exhales through his nose.

“You keep talking about Wulf and Friedhelm like...” He struggles for the shape of it. “Like they were your whole world.”

Leora’s expression changes faintly.

Not defensive.

Almost guilty.

“They were,” she says honestly.

Then after a pause:

“So was Sukuna.”

That catches him off guard.

Because she says it without hesitation.

Without weighing one against the other.

Leora's fingers drift absently against the front of his robe.

"When Sukuna found me," she says quietly, "I had already stopped believing people could want things without eventually turning cruel about them."

Chōbei listens carefully.

"He terrified me."

A small smile touches her mouth then.

"He still does sometimes."

That should almost sound playful.

Instead it sounds sincere.

"He looked at me like he wanted every ugly thing I kept hidden." Her eyes unfocus slightly. "And he never once asked me to become easier to hold."

Chōbei feels something tighten painfully in his chest at that.

"He gave me children," she says softly. "A home. Space to become something besides survival."

Then quieter:

"He let Friedhelm stay."

That lands heavily too.

Because Chōbei suddenly understands Sukuna did not merely tolerate Friedhelm.

He accepted him as part of Leora's life completely.

Leora shifts slightly in his lap.

"He never tried to separate us."

The words sound important.

Sacred almost.

Then Chōbei asks the question that has been sitting like poison in him since she first spoke Wulf's name.

"...Is this the same Wulf?"

Leora looks at him.

"The one who kidnapped you when Tsukihiko was four and the twins were two?"

Her expression stills completely.

"The same man who married you and kept you for three months?"

Silence.

"The same Wulf Sukuna asked if he was Kurohiko's real father?"

Leora answers quietly.

"Yes."

Chōbei almost cannot reconcile it.

The stories do not fit together properly in his head.

The tenderness.

The culling.

The escape.

The kidnapping.

The marriage.

The fact Sukuna let her return without tearing the world apart afterward.

And then another thought comes.

One he hates immediately.

But he asks it anyway.

"...Were you telling the truth?"

Leora's brows knit slightly.

"When you came back," Chōbei says carefully, "and told Sukuna you were untouched."

His throat feels tight suddenly.

“I wouldn’t have blamed you for lying.”

That hurts to admit.

“But he believed you instantly.”

Chōbei’s gaze drops briefly.

“He said you wouldn’t lie to him.” A pause. “He said you are truth.”

Leora goes very still.

“And now,” Chōbei says quietly, “I’m wondering if Sukuna even knows any of this.”

Leora watches him for a moment.

Then answers simply:

“I was untouched.”

No hesitation.

No shame.

“Wulf kissed me.”

Her eyes lower.

“He tried to convince me to stay.”

A pause.

“To re-enter the system.”

Chōbei’s jaw tightens immediately.

But Leora shakes her head faintly.

“He would never have forced me.”

And Chōbei believes her.

Strangely, horribly, he believes her completely.

Which only makes this harder to understand.

Because from where he stands now—

none of this makes sense.

“Then why?” he asks before he can stop himself.

Leora looks up.

“Why would you even think about staying?”

The question comes out rougher than he intends.

“Why were you even open to being with Wulf again?”

His chest aches now.

“What about your children?”

Another beat.

“What about Sukuna?”

Leora suddenly looks exhausted.

Not offended.

Not angry.

Just tired in a way that reaches bone deep.

Then quietly:

“Wulf lied to the tribes.”

Chōbei stills.

“He told them I didn’t have a daughter.”

His stomach drops immediately.

Leora’s eyes drift away again.

“He entered another culling.”

A pause.

“And won me again.”

The room feels colder suddenly.

“If he hadn’t,” she says softly, “I would have been married to someone else.”

Chōbei already knows where this is going before she says it.

But hearing it anyway makes him feel sick.

“Someone whose express purpose would have been making me conceive another Alraune.”

His hand tightens against her instinctively.

Leora notices.

Always.

“If I stayed with Wulf,” she whispers, “Kaguya would have been safe.”

Chōbei’s breath catches.

“I could have another daughter.”

The words sound horrifyingly practical.

“Then my children with Sukuna would be left alone.”

She closes her eyes briefly.

“But really...” Her voice frays slightly there. “I considered it because Friedhelm had already suffered four years collared, raped, and abused.”

Chōbei feels her shaking now.

Small.

Controlled.

Worse because she is trying to hide it.

“And for what?” she whispers.

“For me?”

Her eyes open again.

Raw now.

“I was born to be used and thrown away.”

Chōbei immediately grips her harder.

As if physically rejecting the sentence.

But Leora keeps going anyway.

“He wasn’t.”

A tear finally slips free.

“Friedhelm was born resplendent and pure.”

Her voice breaks quietly there.

“He was meant to live.”

The grief inside that sentence is unbearable because it is not romantic.

It is reverence.

“I thought...” She swallows hard. “If I stayed, maybe I could get him out the way he got me out.”

Her fingers curl weakly into Chōbei’s robe.

“Maybe he could live under Sukuna’s protection.”

A tiny breath.

“Maybe he could stay with my children.”

Then finally, quietly:

“That was what I was considering.”

Chōbei does not realize he is holding her too tightly until Leora’s hand slides over his wrist gently.

Not to stop him.

Just to soothe the pressure from his grip.

The realization makes him loosen immediately.

But he does not let go.

He cannot.

Leora stays in his lap facing him, one knee tucked against his hip, her hands resting lightly against his chest now like she is grounding herself against the rhythm of his breathing.

The room has become painfully quiet.

Even the candles seem softer now.

Chōbei looks at her for a long moment before speaking again.

“And when you came back...”

His throat feels rough.

“You said you were untouched.”

Leora closes her eyes briefly.

Then she answers again.

“Yes.”

But this time there is more behind it.

More exhaustion.

More honesty.

“I was untouched in the way that would have called paternity into question.”

The words land heavily.

Carefully chosen.

“But I was touched.”

Chōbei stills.

Leora’s gaze lowers.

“He held me.”

A pause.

“Kissed me.”

Her fingers curl once lightly against his chest.

“And I will not apologize for it.”

There is no defiance in her voice.

Only something painfully human.

Because after everything she has told him—

apology would almost be obscene.

Leora swallows.

“...Maybe it just felt good,” she says quietly, “to finally have a taste of what we never could when he was only my Gegner and I was only his ward.”

The sadness in that sentence is unbearable.

Not because it sounds romantic.

Because it sounds starved.

Chōbei cannot even imagine what it must have been like to grow up beside someone your entire life while every rule around you turned tenderness into danger.

Leora looks away slightly.

Then back at him again.

“You asked what about Sukuna,” she says softly. “What about when I met him after escaping.”

Chōbei listens carefully.

And then she says something that changes the shape of everything he thought he understood.

“Well...” A tiny pause. “First, I survived Wulf.”

The room goes still around the sentence.

Not survived *with* him.

Survived *him*.

Meaning the loss.

The aftermath.

The tearing apart of whatever future had once existed.

Leora's voice lowers.

"Then I met Sukuna."

And suddenly Chōbei understands with painful clarity:

Sukuna did not replace Wulf.

He entered the ruins afterward.

He found her after hope had already been broken open.

After escape.

After violence.

After grief.

After she had already learned what it meant to lose everything at once.

Leora exhales shakily.

"Sukuna was..." She searches for it. "Alive in a way I had never seen before."

A faint smile touches her mouth despite herself.

"Terrible."

That almost pulls a laugh out of Chōbei.

Almost.

"He wanted everything honestly." Her eyes flicker toward him. "Even the ugly things."

And Chōbei suddenly understands something else too.

Something that settles cold and heavy into his ribs.

Every person who has ever loved Leora has eventually become violent toward the structure around her.

Wulf.

Friedhelm.

Sukuna.

Now him.

Because Chōbei feels it now with horrifying clarity:

the instinct to tear apart anything that would reduce her back into survival.

And suddenly another realization follows right behind it.

Sukuna knew.

That day earlier—

the way Sukuna looked at him.

The ease.

The recognition.

He had seen the pattern immediately.

Chōbei was becoming another man reorganizing himself around keeping Leora alive.

The realization unsettles him so deeply he almost goes cold.

Leora notices the shift instantly.

“Chōbei?”

He looks at her.

Really looks at her.

At the tiredness in her eyes.

The softness she only allows in pieces.

The brutality she survived.

The impossible contradictions of her.

And he realizes with a kind of dreadful certainty that loving her means eventually positioning yourself against something larger than yourself.

Not because she asks.

Because remaining still becomes unbearable once you understand what was done to her.

Leora touches his face gently then.

Right over the scars.

Her thumb strokes once across his cheek.

And very quietly she asks:

“What are you thinking?”

Chōbei stares at her for a long moment before answering.

“That I understand Sukuna better now.”

Something flickers across her expression at that.

Not fear.

Not surprise.

Recognition.

Wulf takes Friedhelm's Place

Scene selection: Kiyomi in the Threads witnesses Wulf offer himself in place of Friedhelm for physical and sexual abuse/violation

Kiyomi was already unmoored when the next memory took her.

Not because she expected clarity anymore.

But because something in her had begun resisting the idea that clarity even existed here.

The space formed slowly.

Not a garden.

Not a den.

A room.

Closed.

Heavy.

Air thick with something metallic and stale.

Blood.

It clung to the floorboards in dark, dried patches that had already been half-cleaned, smeared into absence rather than removed.

A bed sat against the far wall.

Sheets disordered.

Wrinkled.

Torn in places that did not need explanation.

Kiyomi saw Friedhelm first.

He was standing.

Barely.

Not moving.

Not reacting.

Not breathing like a person who was present in his own body.

Collar around his neck.

Marks across his skin.

Bruises layered over older bruises, as if time itself had given up trying to protect him.

There was blood on the floor near his feet.

A body nearby.

Dead.

Unimportant.

Already discarded by meaning.

Friedhelm did not look at it.

Did not look at anything.

He looked like something that had been left standing after the soul had been removed.

Kiyomi's stomach turned.

She could not stop it.

Not because of violence.

Because of stillness.

Because nothing in him responded.

Then Wulf was there.

On the floor.

Not standing.

Not composed.

Collapsed in a way that felt entirely unworthy of the body she had come to know as unstoppable.

His hands covered his face.

His shoulders shook.

The sound that came from him was not controlled.

Not restrained.

Ugly.

Raw.

It tore through the room like something that had never been allowed to exist inside him and was finally breaking free.

Kiyomi froze.

She did not understand this version of him.

Not yet.

Not like this.

Wulf's breath hitched.

Again.

And again.

As if he were trying to inhale something that refused to enter his lungs.

Then slowly—

like a body remembering it still had function—

he stood.

Crossed the room.

And took Friedhelm into his arms.

Kiyomi felt something inside her recoil so violently she nearly lost balance.

It wasn't tenderness that shocked her.

It was scale.

Wulf held Friedhelm like something sacred.

Not fragile.

Not broken.

Sacred.

Like a disciple holding a prophet after revelation.

Like something older than love.

Older than grief.

Older than language that could name either.

His hands settled carefully along Friedhelm's back.

Steadying.

Not restraining.

Friedhelm did not resist.

Did not respond.

Wulf bent his head into him.

And stayed there for a long moment.

As if the act of breathing near him was the only thing keeping the world from collapsing.

Then he moved.

He cleaned the blood.

Slowly.

Methodically.

As though each motion mattered in a way Kiyomi could not understand.

Washbasin nearby.

Water darkening as it touched him.

He wiped Friedhelm's skin with a gentleness that did not belong in a room like this.

Removed what could be removed.

Not to erase.

To restore.

To return.

Clothes followed.

Careful.

Precise.

As if even fabric placement was part of a ritual that could not be interrupted without consequence.

Then he dressed him.

Not as one would dress a body.

As one would prepare something cherished for continuity.

Friedhelm did not move.

Did not speak.

Did not exist in any way Kiyomi could anchor herself to.

Wulf leaned in.

His mouth near Friedhelm's hair.

"Beloved," he said.

The word landed wrong.

Not because it was unfamiliar.

Because it was too intimate for language to safely hold.

He kissed him.

Once.

Then again.

And then lingered there, eyes closed, as if contact itself was the only truth remaining.

He scented him after.

Not possessively.

Not violently.

As if confirming presence.

As if refusing absence.

Kiyomi's vision blurred.

Something inside her tried to reject what it was seeing.

Not morally.

Existentially.

Because this level of intimacy did not belong in memory.

It felt like trespass.

Then her eyes caught it.

The mark on Wulf's neck.

The bite scar.

The one she had seen before.

And now—

above Friedhelm's heart.

Another bite mark.

Matched.

Mirrored.

Kiyomi understood without needing explanation.

Not intellectually.

Instinctively.

Devouring vow.

Not metaphor.

Not symbol.

Exchange written into flesh.

Something that bound them beyond language.

Beyond ownership.

Beyond separation.

Her breath caught.

Because suddenly the scars she had seen before were no longer isolated.

They were part of a system.

A geometry of belonging.

And then—

the door opened.

A man entered.

Kiyomi knew him before anyone spoke.

Not by name.

By presence.

Authority carried without effort.

Friedrich.

Leora and Friedhelm's father.

He looked at the room once.

Then at Wulf.

Wulf straightened immediately.

The shift was instant.

Not obedience.

Reaction.

Instinctive.

A man bracing against something that had shaped him before he understood how to stand.

Fear.

Controlled.

Contained.

But present.

Friedrich smiled.

It did not reach his eyes.

“You killed Dragomir’s son,” he said lightly. “He earned his time with Friedhelm.”

Wulf’s expression tightened.

Something in him cracked at the edges.

“I want this to stop.”

The words came out uneven.

Not strong.

Not declarative.

Worn down by repetition.

Friedrich raised an eyebrow.

“He’s responsible for creating a new Alraune.”

A pause.

Wulf made a sound Kiyomi had never heard from him before.

Distress without restraint.

Raw refusal without strategy.

“He can’t do that with a man,” Wulf said. “You know that.”

Friedrich shrugged.

“Some men want to try.”

That was when Wulf looked like something was being taken from him in real time.

Not metaphorically.

Visibly.

Like each sentence removed something vital.

“I want him with me,” Wulf said.

Friedrich’s smile returned.

“You want to make a deal.”

Wulf hesitated.

Just once.

And in that hesitation Kiyomi felt something cold spread through her chest.

Fear.

Not for Friedhelm.

For Wulf.

Friedrich tilted his head.

“Then take his place with me, and I’ll let you take him to your home afterwards.”

Silence.

It swallowed the room.

Wulf turned his head slowly.

Looked at Friedhelm.

Not as a possession.

Not as an object.

As something held together by the only thing still anchoring him to the world.

Kiyomi tried to speak.

Tried to scream.

No sound came.

Not because she was silent.

Because the memory did not allow refusal.

Wulf lifted Friedhelm carefully.

As if weight itself mattered less than alignment.

Carried him back to the bed.

Set him down with reverence that did not match the horror of the room.

Then he straightened.

Turned.

Looked at Friedrich.

And nodded.

Once.

Friedrich smiled as if satisfied.

“Good wolf.”

He turned and left.

Wulf followed.

Without hesitation.

Without looking back.

And Kiyomi was left standing in a room that no longer had meaning except what had just been taken from it.

She was shaking.

Not from fear alone.

From recognition she did not want.

And then—

the memory broke again.

The Brother's Story

Scene Selection: Kiyomi in the Threads witnesses Wulf tell Leora in the Past the story about her brother Friedhelm

Kiyomi was still in the water when the next memory seized her.

There was no transition. No descent. Only rupture—like something tearing open inside the mind of reality itself—and suddenly she was somewhere else again, existing without the agreement of a body.

At first it was just sensation.

Cold air.

A room.

The faint weight of something wrong pressing into everything.

Then it resolved.

Wulf stood in the center of a chamber she did not recognize.

Leora was there.

Not as Kiyomi knew her.

Not invincible.

Not untouchable.

She was upright but unsteady, as though something in her had been forcibly realigned and had not yet learned how to hold itself in place.

Wulf did not sit.

Did not pace.

He simply stood in front of her.

Composed in a way that felt unnatural, as if stillness had been chosen rather than inherited.

When he spoke, it was not explanation.

It was narration.

“There was once a boy,” he said. “Born into a house that did not belong to itself.”

Leora did not move.

Did not interrupt.

“He was meant to lead,” Wulf continued. “That was his future. His function. His inheritance.”

A pause.

“He was strong. Kind. Beloved by those who needed him to be.”

Something in Leora’s expression tightened—but she remained silent.

“And he had a sister.”

Wulf’s voice lowered slightly.

“She was not meant to lead. She was meant to be used. Shaped. Given away when necessary.”

Leora’s fingers curled faintly at her sides.

“But the boy did not accept that.”

Silence pressed into the room.

“He fed her when she was starved. Protected her when she was beaten. Stayed when others did not.”

A step closer—not threatening. Just inevitable.

“He made a mistake.”

Leora’s voice broke through, quiet and unsteady.

“...Loving her.”

“Yes,” Wulf said immediately.

No hesitation.

Only certainty.

“He decided she would not live as she was meant to live.”

Leora’s breath caught.

“So he took her.”

The words did not rise.

They settled.

Heavy.

Final.

“And for a time,” Wulf said, “he believed that meant it was over.”

Leora’s throat tightened.

“But the world does not end where belief does.”

A shift in his tone—not emotional, but heavier.

“They caught him.”

Leora’s face changed then. Not fully. Not visibly breaking. But something inside her recognizing a path she already knew the shape of.

“They made an example of him,” Wulf continued.

The room felt colder.

“They bound him. And told him what she was meant to be without him.”

Leora’s breathing became uneven.

“They did not kill him quickly.”

Her hands clenched.

“They ensured he understood.”

A silence stretched.

Long enough that it felt like something listening.

“And when he died,” Wulf said—

Leora’s voice snapped.

“No.”

He continued anyway.

“They brought him back.”

Her body faltered slightly.

“...no,” she repeated, weaker.

“Not as he was.”

The words were flat.

Clinical.

Absolute.

“They carved obedience into him. Into his body. Into his voice.”

Leora’s vision blurred.

“They made him lead.”

A pause.

“He speaks. He smiles. He commands.”

Wulf’s eyes did not soften.

“And none of it is his.”

The room did not move.

But something inside it did.

“He cannot die.”

Leora’s breath broke.

Silence followed—dense, suffocating.

Then Wulf stepped closer.

Not to corner her.

Not to threaten her.

Just close enough that she could not avoid the weight of what he was saying.

“This is not an old story,” he said.

Her eyes lifted to him.

Unsteady.

Shattered at the edges.

“It is still happening.”

A pause.

Then, quietly:

“His name is Friedhelm Ten Brinken.”

The name landed like impact.

Leora’s knees almost gave—but she forced herself to remain upright.

Her voice came out raw.

“...You let that happen?”

Wulf did not look away.

“No.”

A beat.

“I kept him alive.”

Something in her expression cracked—not into disbelief, but something worse.

Understanding.

“...that’s what you call mercy?” she whispered.

“Yes.”

No defense.

No justification.

Only conviction.

And Kiyomi—watching from somewhere that was not a body—felt it shift.

Not just grief.

Not just horror.

But structure.

A world where love and survival and violation could exist in the same sentence without contradiction.

Leora stared at him for a long moment.

And for the first time—

she did not argue.

Not because she agreed.

But because she understood something far more dangerous:

Wulf believed every word he had spoken.

And belief like that did not negotiate.

It only continued.

And somewhere far beneath them—

in a place that did not reflect light correctly—

something in the root-system of the world twitched.

Then went still.

Songs

Wulf's unique sound

He Remembered My Shape

Hann Mundi Lögun Mína

Vatnit hevði longu tikið navnið mítt
The water had already taken my name

áðrenn hann fann meg
before he found me

Røturnar kendi tað
The roots knew it

Hungrið kendi tað
The hunger knew it

Teir deyðu kendi tað
The dead knew it

Men eingin talaði tað rætt
But none spoke it correctly

Eg varð nógv ting
I became many things

áðrenn hann kom
before he came

Veidimaður
Hunter

Rót
Root

Sár
Wound

Minni
Memory

Tenn
Teeth

Einki av tí var lygn
None of it was a lie

Men einki av tí var alt
Yet none of it was all

Hann gekk niður í deyðans vatn
He walked into the waters of death

Ikki fyri at finna ein heilagan mann
Not to find a holy man

Ikki fyri at finna ein góðan mann
Not to find a good man

Men fyri at finna meg
But to find me

Hann hugdi ikki at syndum mínum
He did not look at my sins

Ikki at óttanum hjá øðrum
Nor the fear of others

Ikki at tí sum røturnar gjørdi meg til
Nor what the roots made of me

Hann hugdi at tí sum eftir stóð
He looked at what remained

Og eg hataði hann fyri tað
And I hated him for it

Tí viðurkenning sker djúpari enn dómur
Because recognition cuts deeper than judgment

Dómur kann verða avvístur
Judgment can be dismissed

Dómur kann verða stríddur ímóti
Judgment can be fought

Men viðurkenning kennir beinini
But recognition knows the bones

Røturnar róptu meg sín
The roots called me theirs

Deyðin rópti meg sín
Death called me theirs

Harmurin rópti meg hennara
Grief called me hers

Hann rópti meg Wulf
He called me Wulf

Sum um tað avgjörði málið
As though that settled the matter

Sum um eingin annar hevði nakað at siga
As though no one else had a claim

Og ein ella annan veg
And somehow

Avgjörði tað alt
It settled everything

Hann tók meg ikki úr vatninum sum hetju
He did not pull me from the water as a hero

Ikki sum kong
Nor as a king

Ikki sum frelsara
Nor as a savior

Hann tók meg sum mannin eg hevði verið
He pulled me out as the man I had been

Og tá hann bygdi meg aftur
And when he built me again

Broytti hann einki
He changed nothing

Ikki hendur mínar
Not my hands

Ikki arrini
Not my scars

Ikki hungrið
Not the hunger

Bara løgnina
Only the distortion

Tí hann mintist
Because he remembered

Longur enn eg sjálvur megnaði
Longer than I could

Hvør eg var
Who I was

This version ties directly into the line you established with Leora and Friedhelm:

"I fashioned his soul anew after plucking him from the waters of death. He is as he was before the roots."

The emotional climax isn't resurrection.

It's:

"He remembered longer than I could."

For someone like Wulf, who spent decades being consumed by the roots, I think that's the most devastating gratitude he could possibly express.

Song of the Rib Cage

Rifja-Söngur

Ek kann rif þín
I know your ribs

betr enn flestar leiðir
better than I know most roads

Hönd mín finn þau í myrkri
My hand finds them in darkness

án leitar
without searching

án orða
without words

Holur milli beina
The hollows between bone

undir vetrfeldi
beneath winter fur

hæg öndun
slow breathing

örugg
certain

órofin
unbroken

segir mér
telling me

þú ert hér enn
you are still here

Vargar leggjast
The wolves settle

einn af öðrum
one by one

kringum eldinn
around the fire

Snær safnast úti
Snow gathers outside

Nótt lokast
Night closes

veröld minnkar
The world becomes smaller

þar til aðeins
until only

andardráttur þinn
your breathing

lifir undir hendi minni
lives beneath my hand

Þú ilmar af frosti
You smell of frost

furu
pine

vargfeldi
wolf fur

og fjarlægum stormum
and distant storms

Lykt þín fyllir skála
Your scent fills the den

þar til jafnvel svefn
until even sleep

fylgir henni heim
follows it home

Ek svaf hjá hungri
I have slept beside hunger

hjá ótta
beside fear

hjá deyjandi mönnum
beside dying men

með hönd á vápni
with a hand on a weapon

mestan hluta lífs míns
for most of my life

En hjá þér
But beside you

gleyma hendur mínar
my hands forget

hverju þær voru skapaðar til
what they were made for

Þá er þú dregur mik nær
When you pull me close

þarf ek eigi vaka yfir dyrum
I do not need to watch the door

hlusta eftir skrefum
listen for footsteps

telja flóttaleiðir
or count escape routes

Vargar gera þat
The wolves do that

Þú gerir þat
You do that

Og um stund
And for a little while

er ek aðeins maður
I am only a man

Þú biðr mik eigi vera mýkri
You do not ask me to become softer

eigi helgari
nor holier

eigi betri
nor better

Aðeins vera
Only to remain

Því áður en rætur
For before the roots

áður en hungrið
before the hunger

áður en ek glataði lögun minni
before I lost my shape

var maður
there was a man

Og þú mundir hann
And you remembered him

nógu lengi
long enough

til at skapa hann á ný
to build him again

The Hunger Prayer

This one should not be about Wulf.

It should sound ancient.

Like something hunters sing in winter.

The kind of song mothers know.

The kind spoken when children are becoming thin.

The kind spoken before impossible choices.

Vagr

Hoyr okkum
Hear us

Snøggur er veturin í ár
Winter is harsh this year

Og börnini telja bein síni
And the children count their ribs

Leið okkum til tað sum enn rennur

Lead us to what still runs

Til hjörtini undir kavanum

To the hearts beneath the snow

Lat okkum koma fram áðrenn hungrið ger tað

Let us arrive before hunger does

Og um vit mugu velja

And if we must choose

tað eingin faðir eigur at velja

what no father should choose

tað eingin móðir eigur at velja

what no mother should choose

so hygg ikki burtur

then do not look away

Sit hjá okkum í myrkrinum

Sit beside us in the dark

Ver hjá teimum sum bera skuldina

Remain with those who carry the guilt

Tí tú kennir hungur
For you know hunger

Og tú kennir eisini kærleika
And you know love also

Og stundum síggja tey eins út
And sometimes they look the same